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SPORTS

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Shoremen fall short

By JASON LLOYD
Morning Journal Writer

AVON LAKE — Those hands that pushed Avon Lake within one night of a Southwestern Conference championship ...

Those hands that were already responsible for 24 points on this night ...

Those hands that wanted to touch an SWC trophy before graduation ...

As it all slipped away, Brian Ingleright was now cursing those same hands.

Olmsted Falls 81, Avon Lake 72. Six straight SWC titles for the Bulldogs. One goal lost for the Shoremen.

"This is pretty devastating," Ingleright said. "It's hard to lose the league like this."

Avon Lake finishes 17-3 overall, 12-2 in the SWC. The Bulldogs are 15-4 overall, 13-1 in the conference with a meaningless non-conference game left tonight.

"We played hard in the second half," Ingleright said. "But it wasn't enough."

It wasn't enough because of the 46-31 hole the Shoremen jumped in by halftime.

"We knew we'd have to play very good to win," Ingleright said. "But in the first half we played pretty bad."

But Ingleright and Tom Port tried to forgive that bad half with a furious second-half return.

Port on a rebound and basket.

Ingleright with a 3-pointer from the concession stand.

Port on a dunk.

Ingleright with a runner through the lane.

"We wanted to contain Port, and that didn't work. Then we wanted to contain Ingleright, and that didn't work," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said. "Finally we thought we better just outscore them."

With "Mike Gansey and his Merry Men," as Donahue called them, it's not a bad idea.

Port brought the sellout crowd to its feet early in the third with a monster dunk, but Falls' Joe Stanton ran right back down the floor with a twisting runner through the lane.

Ingleright slashed through the lane with a short runner, but Gansey came right back with a basket high off the glass.

"Overall in the second half we played well," Avon Lake coach Dave Olinger said. "We eventually cut the lead to five."

And it was then that Ingleright cursed the hands that brought the Shoremen so far.

Avon Lake shot and shot and shot that 15-point deficit down to five. After a Gansey free

throw made it 74-68, Ingleright looked at the 1:30 that remained on the clock and heaved another 3-pointer in front of Olinger. It's these long 3-pointers that makes Olinger cringe at times, but it's those same 3-pointers that brought the Shoremen back last night.

"Coach always tells me to be patient," Ingleright says. "But if I feel like I can knock down my shot, I'll shoot 'em."

He had already made four of those bombs. A fifth would cut the Bulldogs lead to just three and set up a sequel to the buzzer-beating show-stopper these two teams staged just last month, when Avon Lake handed Falls its only conference loss of the year.

But this time the sweat had caught up with Ingleright.

The sweat from playing 32 straight minutes, the sweat from the anticipation of a conference championship and the sweat created from 2,800-plus shoe-horned into Avon Lake's Fieldhouse screaming and chanting all four quarters.

The ball slipped from Ingleright's hands up on release. It jumped awkwardly off the right side of the rim and aimlessly rolled out of bounds, taking with it any chance of a Shoremen championship.

"It was so hot at that end of the court," Ingleright said. "The ball slipped out of my hands."

But this game wasn't lost on that 3-point attempt. It was lost in the first half, when poor passing, sloppy ball-handling and lazy defense allowed the Bulldogs to open a 22-10 lead just seven minutes into the game.

"This is unbelievable, we've gone through so much," said a raspy Mike Gansey, exhausted after scoring 31 points. "Avon Lake is an unbelievable team."

But so are the Bulldogs.

Gansey hit 3-pointers, he blocked shots, he caught an errant pass off an alley-oop parallel to the backboard and still slid it through the basket.

And in the end, that 15-point halftime grave was too big for Ingleright's hands.

"He did an excellent job offensively," Olinger said of Ingleright. "I have a hard time giving him rest. I know I need to give him rest, but he's just so important to our team."

Ingleright finished with 26 points. Port had 20, Rob Curry had 10 and Justin Booher had 9, all on 3-pointers.

These two teams could meet a third time in sectionals, which begin next weekend.

"Last year we beat them two out of three games," Ingleright said. "We know we can play with them. We won't back down from anybody."

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Garry Reitter, left, tries to draw the charge as Brian Ingleright of Avon Lake tosses up a reverse layup yesterday in the fourth quarter.

SAINTS

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"We came out and set the tone, but Sandusky closed with a 6-0 run and we knew it would be a dog fight from that point on," McConihe said.

The Streaks took their first lead of the night in the second quarter. Trailing 25-21, Sandusky went on a commanding 11-2 run in the final three minutes of the first half to pull ahead, 32-27.

Redding, who finished with a team-high 18 points and a game-high 13 rebounds, sparked the Streaks during the run with a putback, two free throws and a 10-footer.

"Redding really had his way with us and we didn't do a good job on our assignment," McConihe said. "I felt like he told his teammates, 'get on my back and I'll carry you through this game.'"

Along with Redding and Heath, the Streaks were led in scoring by Nate Matthews (11), Antoine Stockette (10) and Steve Wooten (eight). Kevin Boyd and Renaldo Collins scored 12 points each to pace Rios.

In jayvee action, Sandusky came away with a hard-fought 60-54 double-overtime victory. Dustin Truman hit a half-court 3-pointer for the Streaks to send the game into OT.

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PATRIOTS

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season going into the Division IV tournament. With the 19 wins, Open Door broke a school record for most wins in a season. That mark breaks the record of 17-4 in 1989.

Lake Ridge heads into the tournament facing the number three seed in Independence.

Open Door has a first round bye. In the jayvee game, Open Door beat the Royals, 56-49.

CLIPS

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who drove the lane and put the ball through the 18-inch cylinder with one second left in the game.

The play was the crowning touch as the Clippers battled back from a 16-point first half deficit to win 53-51, ending the regular season with a 9-11 overall record and 5-9 in the Lorain County Conference.

The Clippers did the unusual last night, starting seniors Pito Elliott, Eric Guerrieri, Michael Pallens, Tim Mills and Dustin Morog, who normally see a lot of action but are called in from the bench.

"The starting five was predicated on (Thursday) night's practice," Clearview coach John Szalay said. "It was probably the best practice that we had all year, and these are the kids who always put the team first. Tonight the normal starters put the team first and wanted the seniors to start this game."

The seniors, who have been good role players for the Clippers all year, were no match for the Middies starting five. Midview pulled out to an early 11-0 lead before Szalay could get the starting unit on the floor to stop the bleeding.

With 4:04 left in the quarter, Szalay hit a 3-pointer to give his team their first points of the night. Szalay added a free throw, as did Thornton, but the Middies held a 15-5 lead entering second-quarter action.

The Clippers held their own against the Middies in the second, with both teams scoring 17 points to go to halftime with Midview leading, 32-21.

Aaron Fox led the Middies in the first half with nine points, while Szalay was leading his team with 11.

"Aaron did a good job for us in that first half," Midview coach Troy DiFranco said. "The only problem was the fact that he had three personal fouls, and we could not play him as much as we needed to in the second half."

The Clippers outscored the Middies 19-7 in the third quarter and took a 40-39 lead into the final eight minutes of play.

Thornton provided the spark that Clearview needed to start their comeback, hitting three triples, with the last one bringing his team within 34-32 at the halfway point in the quarter. Noble scored his only points of the game with a bucket at the 1:25 mark, but it was a big, tying the game at 38. Szalay scored the go-

ahead points as the quarter came to a close and the Clippers led 40-39.

"Thornton hitting those shots to start the second half was the difference in this game," DiFranco said. "He gave them the momentum when they needed it and he set the tone for the rest of the contest."

The score was tied twice in the final quarter at 44 and 51 before Szalay's heroics. The freshman guard ended the season by averaging over 15 points a game.

"I can't remember who hit me with the pass, but I remembered I rolled middle and drove baseline and all of a sudden there was the basket," the younger Szalay said. "I was really nervous, but when I saw the ball fall through the net I realized that we had just won the ballgame."

Midview, who ended the regular season at 8-12 and 7-7 in the LCC, were led by Fox, who scored 16 points and Ryan Feierabend, who hit for 11 points and a game-high 17 rebounds.

The Clippers were led by Szalay and Thornton, who scored 22 and 11 points respectively.

The Middies won the jayvee contest 32-26 as Mike Worley led the winners with 10 points, while Tom Molich scored 19 for the Clippers.

By JAMES BRADY
Morning Journal Correspondent

AMHERST — Just last weekend it looked like Amherst was heading in the wrong direction at the wrong time losing a tough game at home against Vermilion.

What a difference a week makes!

The Comets whipped Wellington on Tuesday night and last night Amherst closed out the regular season with a 54-48 win over Rocky River to give the Comets an 11-9 overall record (8-6 in SWC play) heading into tournament play next week against SWC foe North Olmsted.

Amherst used a simple formula to grab the win from the Pirates: Play much better defense in the second half and let the two seniors take over the game when it counted.

The Comets duo of Kyle Karpinski and Zach Crowther gave Amherst everything it needed - scoring 23 and 21 points respectively. Karpinski and Crowther also combined to pull down 12 rebounds.

"Zach and Kyle really stepped it up and did exactly what seniors are supposed to do with the game on the line," Comets head coach Mitch Gilliam, Jr. said.

They wanted to help establish something here at Amherst as they wanted to be part of a group

to build a winning program. Now we have some unfinished business in the tournament."

Despite shooting 50 percent from the floor (11-of-22) in the first half, the Comets found themselves on the short end of the score-

board, 27-23.

That's when Crowther and Karpinski took over the game. Karpinski would score six points in the third quarter and Crowther would tally eight, including a 3-pointer.

The Comets were scoring on the offensive end, but it was their work on the defensive end that gave them a 39-33 lead at the end of the third quarter.

Amherst held Rocky River to 2-of-13 from the floor in the third with both baskets coming in the first three minutes of the second half. The Comets also picked up the pace on the boards, outrebounding the Pirates 12-5 in the frame.

River wouldn't go quietly in the final eight minutes getting 3-point baskets from Matt Saunders, Brian Corrigan and Chris Milano to cut the Comets lead to 47-46 with just over four minutes left in the

game. Corrigan led River in scoring last night with 16 points, including a pair of 3s. Saunders made it into double-digits with 12 points.

Karpinski and Crowther combined to hit 5-of-6 free throws in the final minute to preserve the win.

"We said at the half that if we were to win the game we were going to have to do it with rebounding and defense," added Gillam about his team's 21-8 rebounding advantage in the second half. "The entire team went out and did exactly what we asked of them. We are thrilled to finish the year in third place in the SWC as tough as it was this year."

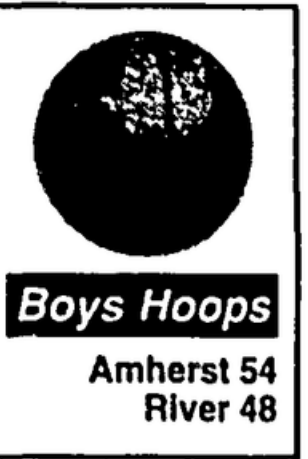
The Comets will face the Eagles on the 28th at Midview High School. The two teams split the two games they played against each other during the year.

Demons Fall to Fairview — Fairview finished the Southwestern Conference season with a win over Westlake behind the 17 points of Jim Rosol.

Westlake (9-11, 5-9) was led by Dan Campana's 10 points.

Fairview improves to 5-15, 2-12 on the season.

The Demons took the junior varsity contest on a last-second shot, 36-34.



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